

The Integration Companion

Your Ketamine Therapy Guide and Journal

Making Sense of Your Ketamine Experience: Why Integration Matters

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Why Integration is Not Optional - It's Essential

Integration is not just a helpful addition to ketamine therapy - it is the bridge between profound experience and lasting healing. Without proper integration, even the most transformative ketamine sessions risk becoming isolated events that fade from memory rather than catalysts for genuine change.

What Happens During Ketamine Sessions

Ketamine temporarily quiets the brain's default mode network - the part responsible for our everyday sense of self and automatic thought patterns. This creates a unique neuroplastic window where:

- Rigid neural pathways soften, allowing new connections to form
- Protective defenses relax, giving access to buried emotions and memories
- Expanded states of consciousness provide fresh perspectives on old wounds
- The nervous system can discharge trapped trauma energy
- Parts of yourself that have been silenced or exiled can finally be heard

The Integration Window: Where Healing Actually Happens

The 24-72 hours following a ketamine session represent a **critical neuroplastic window** when the brain is most receptive to forming new neural pathways. This is when:

Insights Become Wisdom

- Raw experiences transform into actionable understanding
- Symbolic visions reveal their practical meanings
- Emotional breakthroughs translate into behavioral changes
- New neural connections solidify into lasting patterns

Somatic Healing Integrates

- Body sensations and releases need conscious attention to complete
- Nervous system shifts require support to stabilize
- Physical symptoms of trauma can finally begin to resolve
- New embodied awareness becomes your lived experience

What Happens Without Integration

The research is clear, psychedelic experiences without integration show limited lasting benefit. Without integration:

- Insights fade like dreams, losing their transformative power
- Old patterns resurface as the nervous system reverts to familiar states
- Breakthroughs become bypasses - spiritual experiences that don't address underlying wounds
- Therapeutic potential is wasted - sessions become episodic rather than cumulative
- Healing stalls at the level of temporary relief rather than lasting transformation

The Neuroscience of Why Integration Works

Neuroplasticity and Memory Consolidation

- Ketamine opens a window of heightened neuroplasticity
- New neural connections need reinforcement through attention and practice
- Integration practices literally "wire in" new patterns through repetition
- Without conscious reinforcement, old neural highways reassert dominance

Trauma Resolution and Nervous System Regulation

- Trauma lives in the body and nervous system, not just the mind
- Integration helps the nervous system learn new responses to old triggers
- Somatic awareness developed during sessions needs daily practice to maintain
- The window of tolerance gradually expands through consistent attention

Meaning-Making and Post-Traumatic Growth

- The brain is constantly creating meaning from experience
- Without conscious integration, the mind may minimize or forget profound experiences
- Journaling and reflection help encode experiences into long-term memory
- Integration transforms "something happened to me" into "I am capable of healing"

Integration as Relationship with Your Healing

Integration is fundamentally about **developing a conscious relationship with your own healing process**. It means:

- Becoming curious about your inner world rather than afraid of it
- Learning the language of your nervous system and body wisdom
- Honoring the pace of healing rather than forcing outcomes
- Building capacity to hold difficult experiences with compassion
- Creating safety for all parts of yourself to be seen and welcomed

The Compounding Effect of Consistent Integration

Like compound interest, integration builds on itself:

- Week 1: You notice patterns and begin tracking responses
- Month 1: New awareness starts shifting automatic reactions
- Month 3: Healthier patterns become more natural than old ones
- Month 6: Integration becomes a way of life, not just post-session work
- Year 1: You've literally rewired your brain for resilience and well-being

Your Integration Practice: A Sacred Responsibility

Your integration practice is not homework or obligation - it's a valuable responsibility to your own healing. Every moment you spend in conscious relationship with your experience:

- Honors the courage it took to begin this healing journey
- Maximizes the investment you're making in ketamine therapy
- Sends a message to your nervous system that healing is safe and supported
- Creates ripples of healing that extend to your relationships and community
- Becomes a gift to your future self

The Ripple Effect: Beyond Personal Healing

When you commit to integration, you're not just healing yourself:

- Your nervous system regulation affects everyone around you
- Your increased capacity allows you to show up differently in relationships
- Your healing gives others permission to heal
- Your integration models what's possible for others on similar journeys
- Your transformation contributes to collective healing

Starting Your Integration Practice

Remember:

- There is no perfect way to integrate - there is only your way
- Small, consistent practices are more powerful than sporadic intense efforts
- Your nervous system is your guide - if something feels overwhelming, pause
- Integration is a relationship, not a task to complete
- You are not broken - you are courageously healing

Your willingness to prioritize integration demonstrates wisdom, self-respect, and commitment to lasting change. This journal is your companion, witness, and sacred container for one of the most important journeys of your life.

Every entry you make is an act of love toward yourself and an investment in your future freedom.

Pre-Treatment Life Baseline Log

Creating Your Starting Point: Understanding Your Life Before Treatment

This baseline log helps you document how your life looks and feels before beginning ketamine therapy. Having this "before" picture is incredibly valuable for recognizing growth and celebrating the positive changes that emerge during your healing journey.

Use this log for 1-2 weeks before your first treatment to establish your baseline.

Instructions for Use

Fill this out daily for 1-2 weeks before starting treatment. This creates your "before" snapshot that you can look back on to see how far you've come. Be honest and gentle with yourself - this isn't about judgment, it's about creating an accurate starting point so you can celebrate your growth. There are no right or wrong answers - just document your current reality with compassion. Be as honest as possible - the more accurate your baseline, the more you'll appreciate your changes

You deserve healing - every part of your current experience is worthy of compassion and care.

Daily Pre-Treatment Life Log

Date: _____

Morning Check-In

1. How I woke up today:

☐ Refreshed ☐ Tired ☐ Anxious ☐ Peaceful ☐ Groggy ☐ Energized

☐ Other: _____

2. Quality of sleep last night: (1 = terrible, 10 = excellent) _____

3. First thoughts/feelings upon waking:

4. Energy level this morning: (1 = exhausted, 10 = very energized) _____

Daily Life Experience

Home/Living Environment:

How my living space feels today:

☐ Peaceful ☐ Chaotic ☐ Stressful ☐ Safe ☐ Overwhelming ☐ Comfortable

☐ Other: _____

What my home environment is like:

Work/Daily Responsibilities:

How work/responsibilities feel today:

☐ Manageable ☐ Overwhelming ☐ Stressful ☐ Boring ☐ Meaningful

☐ Exhausting ☐ Other: _____

My stress level during daily tasks: (1 = no stress, 10 = extremely stressed) _____

How I handle challenges today:

Relationships Today

Relationships that brought me the most connection:

Type: _____ (family, friend, partner, coworker, pet, etc.)

What happened:

Relationship that felt most challenging:

Type: _____

What happened:

Overall, my relationships today felt:

☐ Supportive ☐ Draining ☐ Distant ☐ Connected ☐ Conflicted ☐ Loving

☐ Other: _____

How comfortable I felt being myself around others:

- ☐ Very comfortable ☐ Somewhat comfortable ☐ Guarded ☐ Hiding parts of myself
☐ Completely closed off ☐ Other: _____

Emotional Experience

Emotions I experienced most today:

- ☐ Joy ☐ Sadness ☐ Anxiety ☐ Anger ☐ Peace ☐ Frustration ☐ Love
☐ Fear ☐ Numbness ☐ Excitement ☐ Shame ☐ Gratitude ☐ Other: _____

Emotional range today: (1 = very narrow/numb, 10 = full range) _____.

How well I handled difficult emotions:

- ☐ Felt them and moved through them ☐ Got stuck in them ☐ Avoided them
☐ Was overwhelmed by them ☐ Numbed them ☐ Other: _____

Physical Experience

How my body feels today:

- ☐ Energized ☐ Tired ☐ Tense ☐ Relaxed ☐ Achy ☐ Strong
☐ Numb ☐ Alive ☐ Heavy ☐ Light ☐ Other: _____

Areas of tension or discomfort:

How connected I feel to my body:

- ☐ Very connected ☐ Somewhat connected ☐ Disconnected ☐ Numb
☐ Uncomfortable ☐ Other: _____

Physical activities today:

How I cared for my body today:

Self-Care and Coping

Ways I took care of myself today:

When I felt stressed or upset, I:

- ☐ Talked to someone ☐ Exercised ☐ Rested ☐ Used substances ☐ Distracted myself
☐ Isolated ☐ Worked more ☐ Other: _____

Habits I engaged in today:

- ☐ Healthy eating ☐ Exercise ☐ Adequate rest ☐ Time in nature
☐ Creative activities ☐ Social connection ☐ Screen time ☐ Substances
☐ Other: _____

How kind I was to myself today: (1 = very critical, 10 = very compassionate) _____

Evening Reflection

Overall, today felt: (1 = very difficult, 10 = very good) _____

My self-care was: ☐ Excellent ☐ Good ☐ Adequate ☐ Poor ☐ Neglected myself

Best moment of my day:

Most challenging moment of my day:

What I'm grateful for today:

How I'm feeling about starting ketamine treatment:

- ☐ Excited ☐ Nervous ☐ Hopeful ☐ Scared ☐ Curious ☐ Skeptical

☐ Ready ☐ Uncertain ☐ Other: _____

What I hope will change through this treatment:

What I want to remember about how my life feels right now:

Life Areas Assessment

Rate how each area felt this week: (1 = really struggling, 10 = thriving)

- Home/Living Environment: _____
- Work/Daily Responsibilities: _____
- Family Relationships: _____
- Friendships: _____
- Romantic/Intimate Relationships: _____
- Physical Health: _____
- Emotional Wellbeing: _____
- Self-Care: _____
- Joy/Creativity: _____
- Overall Life Satisfaction: _____

Area that felt most challenging:

What I most want to change:

Pre-Treatment Life Summary

My Life Right Now

Three words that describe my daily life:

1. _____

2. _____
3. _____

My biggest daily challenges are:

My greatest sources of joy and support are:

How I typically cope with difficult emotions:

What my relationships are generally like:

How I feel in my body most days:

My energy and motivation levels are:

What I hope ketamine therapy will help with:

What I want my life to look like after treatment:

What I'm most grateful for in my life right now:

A message to my future self who will look back on this:

Baseline Measurements for Future Comparison

Current Coping Strategies

When I'm stressed, I typically: (check all that apply)

- ☐ Talk to friends/family ☐ Exercise ☐ Sleep ☐ Work more ☐ Use substances
- ☐ Watch TV/scroll ☐ Eat ☐ Isolate ☐ Get angry ☐ Shut down
- ☐ Clean/organize ☐ Creative activities ☐ Other: _____

When I'm sad, I typically:

- ☐ Cry ☐ Talk to someone ☐ Sleep ☐ Avoid feelings ☐ Get busy
- ☐ Isolate ☐ Use substances ☐ Listen to music ☐ Other: _____

When I'm anxious, I typically:

- ☐ Worry/ruminate ☐ Avoid situations ☐ Talk through fears ☐ Exercise
- ☐ Use substances ☐ Clean/organize ☐ Seek reassurance ☐ Other: _____

Current Relationship Patterns

In relationships, I tend to:

- ☐ Give too much ☐ Take too much ☐ Keep people at distance ☐ Be overly dependent
- ☐ Avoid conflict ☐ Create conflict ☐ People please ☐ Be authentic
- ☐ Other: _____

When someone is upset with me, I:

- ☐ Panic and over-apologize ☐ Get defensive ☐ Shut down ☐ Try to fix it ☐ Blame them
- ☐ Talk it through calmly ☐ Other: _____

Current Self-Relationship

My inner voice is typically:

- ☐ Very critical ☐ Sometimes critical ☐ Neutral ☐ Sometimes kind
- ☐ Very compassionate ☐ Other: _____

I treat myself:

- ☐ Much worse than I treat others ☐ Somewhat worse than others
☐ About the same as others ☐ Better than others ☐ Other: _____

I believe I deserve:

- ☐ Very little good in life ☐ Some good things ☐ The same as others
☐ Good things and happiness ☐ All the love and joy possible

Understanding Your Healing System with Polyvagal Theory

The Wisdom of Your Body and Mind Working Together

Your healing journey isn't about fixing what's broken - it's about understanding and reconnecting with the incredible wisdom already within you. One powerful framework that helps us understand how your system naturally works to protect and heal is Polyvagal Theory. When combined with ketamine therapy, this approach creates a comprehensive map for understanding and supporting your healing process.

Understanding Polyvagal Theory

Your nervous system has been working 24/7 since before you were born, keeping you alive and trying to keep you safe. It's like having an incredibly sophisticated security system that's constantly scanning your environment and your body, making split-second decisions about safety and danger.

Here's the amazing part: Your nervous system isn't broken, even when it feels like it's working against you. It's actually doing exactly what it's designed to do - protect you based on everything it has learned from your life experiences.

Polyvagal Theory: Your Nervous System as Guardian and Guide:

Understanding Your Three Neural Pathways

Your nervous system has three main pathways that evolved to keep you safe and connected:

1. Ventral Vagal: Your Social Connection System

- When active: You feel calm, curious, and connected
- Capacity for: Learning, playing, loving, creating, healing
- Body signals: Relaxed muscles, easy breathing, warm heart
- This is your natural healing state

2. Sympathetic: Your Mobilization System

- When active: Fight or flight responses engage
- Purpose: Mobilize energy to face challenges or escape danger
- Body signals: Racing heart, tight muscles, rapid breathing, hypervigilance
- Adaptive when: Facing real threats or needing energy for action

3. Dorsal Vagal: Your Protection Through Shutdown System

- When active: Freeze, collapse, or dissociation responses
- Purpose: Protect you when fighting or fleeing isn't possible
- Body signals: Numbness, fatigue, disconnection, "checking out"
- Adaptive when: Overwhelm is too much to process

Your Window of Tolerance

Imagine your nervous system capacity as a window:

- Inside the window: You can handle stress and emotions while staying present
- Above the window: Hyperactivated (fight/flight) - too much energy, anxiety, panic
- Below the window: Hypoactivated (freeze/shutdown) - too little energy, depression, numbness

How Trauma Affects Your Nervous System:

When difficult or scary things happen (especially repeatedly or when you're young), your nervous system learns to be extra protective. It's like your security system becomes more sensitive, triggering alarms for things that might not actually be dangerous now.

Trauma isn't what happened to you - trauma is what happens inside your nervous system when it can't complete its natural protective responses.

Common Signs Your Nervous System Learned to Be Extra Protective:

Fight/Flight Patterns:

- Getting anxious or angry "out of nowhere"
- Feeling like you always have to be doing something
- Having trouble sitting still or relaxing
- Reacting strongly to small things
- Feeling like you're always "on" or alert

Shutdown Patterns:

- Going numb when things get difficult
- Feeling disconnected from your body or emotions
- Having trouble caring about things you used to enjoy
- Feeling exhausted even when you haven't done much
- Spacing out or feeling "not really here"

Mixed Patterns:

- Going back and forth between anxiety and numbness
- Feeling wired and tired at the same time
- Having intense emotions followed by feeling nothing at all

How Your Nervous System Heals:

The beautiful truth: Your nervous system has an incredible capacity to heal and learn new responses. Just like it learned to be extra protective, it can learn to feel safe again.

Healing Happens Through:

Safety First:

- Being around people who are calm and caring
- Creating environments that feel peaceful
- Learning you can trust your own body's wisdom
- Building experiences of "I'm okay right now"

Gentle Challenge:

- Slowly expanding your comfort zone
- Learning you can handle difficult feelings without being overwhelmed
- Building confidence in your ability to regulate yourself
- Proving to your nervous system that you're stronger now

Connection and Co-Regulation:

- Being with others who help you feel calm
- Learning that you're not alone in your experiences
- Experiencing healthy relationships where you feel safe
- Sharing your story with people who understand

Somatic (Body) Awareness:

- Learning to notice what your body is telling you
- Understanding your own nervous system signals
- Practicing breathing, movement, and grounding techniques
- Honoring your body's need for rest, movement, or comfort

How Ketamine Helps Your Nervous System Heal:

Ketamine creates a unique opportunity for nervous system healing by:

Temporarily Quieting the Alarm System:

- Your overprotective responses can relax for a while
- This gives you access to states you might not normally reach
- You can experience safety in your body, often for the first time in years

Creating Neuroplastic Opportunities:

- Your brain becomes more flexible and open to new patterns
- Old trauma responses can finally shift and change
- New neural pathways for safety and connection can form

Accessing Your Natural Healing Wisdom:

- You can connect with parts of yourself that hold healing information
- Your body can complete protective responses that got interrupted
- You can experience what safety and connection feel like in your nervous system

Expanding Your Window of Tolerance:

- You can practice staying present with difficult feelings
- You can learn that intense experiences don't have to overwhelm you
- Your capacity to handle life's challenges gradually increases

Practical Ways to Support Your Nervous System Daily:

For Fight/Flight (When You're Above Your Window):

Calm the System Down:

- Long, slow exhale breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 8)
- Cold water on your wrists or face
- Gentle movement like walking or stretching

Ground Yourself:

- Feel your feet on the floor
- Name 5 things you see, 4 things you hear, 3 things you feel
- Hold something with texture (stress ball, soft blanket)
- Remind yourself: "I am safe right now"

For Shutdown (When You're Below Your Window):

Gently Energize:

- Take some deep breaths to get oxygen flowing
- Gentle movement (stretch, walk, dance)
- Warm drink or warm shower
- Listen to uplifting music

Reconnect:

- Look in the mirror and say something kind to yourself
- Touch your heart and feel it beating
- Go outside if possible
- Do something small that makes you feel accomplished

For Building Your Window of Tolerance:

Daily Practices:

- Check in with your body several times a day: "How am I feeling right now?"
- Practice breathing exercises for 5-10 minutes
- Spend time in nature when possible
- Connect with people who help you feel calm and safe
- Move your body in ways that feel good
- Practice gratitude for small moments of peace or joy

Weekly Practices:

- Review what helped you feel regulated this week
- Notice patterns in what triggers your fight/flight or shutdown responses
- Celebrate moments when you stayed in your window during difficulty
- Plan activities that help you feel safe and connected

Understanding Your Unique Nervous System

Every person's nervous system is different, shaped by their unique experiences. What feels safe to one person might feel threatening to another, and that's completely normal.

Your job is to become curious about YOUR nervous system:

- What helps YOU feel safe and regulated?
- What are YOUR early warning signs of activation or shutdown?
- What does YOUR window of tolerance feel like?
- What are YOUR most effective regulation tools?

The Connection to Your Healing Journey

Understanding polyvagal theory helps you:

Make Sense of Your Responses:

- "I'm not crazy or broken - my nervous system is doing what it learned to do"
- "My reactions make perfect sense given my experiences"
- "I can learn new responses now that I understand what's happening"

Be Compassionate with Yourself:

- "My body has been trying so hard to protect me"
- "I can appreciate how hard my nervous system has been working"
- "I can be patient with myself as I learn new patterns"

Work with Your System Instead of Against It:

- "What does my nervous system need right now?"
- "How can I help myself feel safer in this moment?"
- "What would support my healing today?"

Track Your Progress:

- Notice when your window of tolerance expands
- Celebrate moments of staying regulated during difficulty
- Appreciate your growing awareness of your own patterns
- Recognize that healing is happening even when it's subtle

Your Nervous System is Your Ally

Your nervous system isn't your enemy - it's been your protector all along. Now, with understanding and compassion, you can work together with your nervous system to create more safety, connection, and healing in your life.

Remember:

- You are not your nervous system - you have a relationship with it
- Your responses make sense given your experiences
- Healing is possible at any stage of life
- Small changes in nervous system regulation create big changes in life experience
- You have more influence over your nervous system than you might think

Your nervous system has brought you this far. Now you can help it learn that it's safe to relax, connect, and heal.

Internal Family Systems: The Many Faces of Your Wisdom

Introduction: You Are Beautifully Complex

IFS recognizes that you naturally have different aspects or "parts" of yourself - and this is completely normal and healthy. These parts developed to help you navigate life and often carry important wisdom. All of us have different aspects of our personality that show up in different situations.

Think of it like this: You probably act differently at work than you do with close friends, differently when you're stressed than when you're relaxed. These aren't fake versions of you - they're all authentic parts of who you are.

Your Self: The Calm Center

- Your core essence - naturally curious, compassionate, courageous, and calm
- Always present, even when parts are activated
- Your internal healer - knows how to lead with wisdom and love
- Ketamine often helps you access Self when protective parts step back

Protective Parts: Your Inner Guardians

Managers (everyday protectors):

- The Achiever: "If I'm successful, I'll be safe"
- The People Pleaser: "If everyone likes me, I won't be abandoned"
- The Controller: "If I manage everything, nothing bad will happen"
- The Critic: "If I find flaws first, I won't be disappointed"

Firefighters (crisis responders):

- The Rager: Explosive anger when boundaries are crossed
- The Escape Artist: Substances, sex, shopping to avoid pain
- The Rebel: "I'll do whatever I want, no one can control me"

Exiled Parts: Your Tender Wisdom Keepers

- The Hurt Child: Carries pain that needs witnessing
- The Joyful One: Your natural creativity and wonder
- The Angry One: Legitimate rage at injustice
- The Scared One: Important survival information

Part I: Your Protective Parts - Your Inner Security Team

Instructions: Read through these descriptions and check any that feel familiar. Don't overthink it - just notice what resonates.

Manager Parts (Your Daily Protectors)

□ The Achiever/Perfectionist

- Always pushing to do better, be more, accomplish more
- Believes: "If I'm successful enough, I'll be safe/loved/worthy"
- Shows up as: Working late, never feeling "good enough," setting high standards

□ The People Pleaser

- Always putting others' needs first, avoiding conflict
- Believes: "If everyone likes me, I won't be abandoned or rejected"
- Shows up as: Saying yes when you mean no, difficulty with boundaries

□ The Controller/Planner

- Needs to know what's happening, manages details obsessively
- Believes: "If I control everything, nothing bad will happen"
- Shows up as: Over-organizing, anxiety about uncertainty, micromanaging

□ The Caretaker/Rescuer

- Always helping others, taking responsibility for their feelings
- Believes: "If I take care of everyone, I'll be needed and loved"
- Shows up as: Fixing other people's problems, exhaustion from giving too much

□ The Strong One/Stoic

- Never shows vulnerability, always has it together
- Believes: "If I'm strong, I won't get hurt and others can depend on me"
- Shows up as: Difficulty asking for help, pushing through pain

□ The Critic/Judge

- Constantly evaluating, finding flaws in self or others
- Believes: "If I spot problems first, I can avoid disappointment"
- Shows up as: Inner criticism, judging others, never feeling satisfied

□ The Vigilant One

- Always scanning for danger or threats
- Believes: "I must stay alert to keep us safe"
- Shows up as: Hypervigilance, difficulty relaxing, anxiety

Firefighter Parts (Your Crisis Responders)

□ The Rager

- Explosive anger when boundaries are crossed
- Believes: "If I get big and scary, they'll back off"
- Shows up as: Outbursts, road rage, fighting

□ The Escape Artist

- Uses substances, behaviors, or distractions to avoid pain
- Believes: "I need to get away from this feeling right now"
- Shows up as: Drinking, drugs, shopping, sex, scrolling, workaholism

□ The Rebel

- Does the opposite of what's expected or demanded
- Believes: "No one can control me"
- Shows up as: Breaking rules, self-sabotage when things go well

□ The Chaos Creator

- Stirs up drama when things feel too calm or vulnerable
- Believes: "Familiar chaos is safer than unknown peace"
- Shows up as: Starting fights, making impulsive decisions

Your Protective Parts Reflection

Which protective parts did you recognize in yourself?	
Which part feels most active in your daily life right now?	
What do you think this part is protecting you from?	
How long has this part been working so hard for you?	

Part II: Your Exiled Parts - Your Inner Treasures

□ The Hurt Child

- Carries pain from past experiences
- Needs: Comfort, safety, someone to witness their pain
- May show up as: Feeling small, wanting to hide, emotional reactions that feel too big

□ The Scared One

- Holds your fears and worries
- Needs: Protection, reassurance, safety
- May show up as: Anxiety, panic, feeling like something bad will happen

□ The Angry One

- Carries legitimate rage about injustices or harm
- Needs: To be heard, validation, justice
- May show up as: Sudden anger, feeling like you want to scream or fight

□ The Sad One

- Holds grief, loss, disappointment
- Needs: Comfort, permission to cry, someone to care
- May show up as: Deep sadness, crying, feeling heavy

□ The Lonely One

- Yearns for connection and belonging
- Needs: Companionship, understanding, love
- May show up as: Feeling isolated, desperate for connection, fear of abandonment

□ The Joyful One

- Your natural wonder, playfulness, and delight
- Needs: Permission to play, safety to be spontaneous
- May show up as: Sudden happiness, wanting to dance or create, childlike excitement

□ The Creative One

- Your artistic expression, imagination, innovation
- Needs: Time, space, materials, encouragement
- May show up as: Urges to create, daydreaming, seeing beauty everywhere

□ The Wild One

- Your instincts, sexuality, primal energy
- Needs: Freedom, expression, acceptance
- May show up as: Wanting to break free, sexual energy, connection to nature

□ **The Wise One**

- Your intuition, deep knowing, spiritual connection
- Needs: Quiet, respect, trust in its guidance
- May show up as: Gut feelings, dreams, sudden knowing

Your Exiled Parts Reflection:

Which exiled parts did you recognize?	
Which ones feel most hidden or buried in your daily life?	
Which ones do you feel most protective of or worried about?	
Which ones bring you the most joy when they're allowed to emerge?	

Part III: Self - Your Natural Leader

Self is not a part - it's your core essence that naturally knows how to lead with:

- Curiosity instead of judgment
- Compassion instead of criticism
- Calm instead of reactivity
- Connection instead of isolation
- Courage instead of fear
- Creativity instead of rigidity
- Clarity instead of confusion

Recognizing When Self is Leading:

- You feel genuinely curious about your parts instead of frustrated with them
- You can stay present with difficult emotions without being overwhelmed
- You naturally want to care for the hurt parts of yourself
- You feel connected to your own wisdom and intuition
- You can set boundaries with love instead of anger
- You feel grounded and present in your body
- You naturally extend compassion to others

Self Reflection

When do you most feel like your authentic Self?	
What helps you access this calm, centered state?	
How does it feel different when Self is leading versus when parts are in charge?	

Preparing for Ketamine with Parts Awareness

Before Your Session

Which parts feel excited about ketamine therapy?	
Which parts feel nervous or scared?	
What do your protective parts need to hear to feel safer?	
Which exiled parts are you hoping might be witnessed or healed?	
What would it feel like if Self could lead during your session?	

Remember: All Your Parts Are Welcome

Every part of you developed for good reasons and carries important information. There are no "bad" parts - only parts that may be stuck in old roles that no longer serve you.

Your job is not to get rid of parts, but to:

- Get curious about them
- Appreciate how they've helped you
- Help them find new, healthier roles
- Let Self lead with compassion

During ketamine sessions, parts may:

- Step back and let Self lead
- Show up to be witnessed and healed
- Share their stories and needs
- Find new relationships with each other

Trust your system's timing and wisdom. Your parts will reveal themselves when it feels safe.

The Neuroplasticity Revolution:

Your Brain's Capacity to Heal and Change

Your Brain is Constantly Rewiring

One of the most hopeful discoveries in neuroscience is neuroplasticity - your brain's lifelong ability to form new neural connections and reorganize itself. This means:

- Trauma patterns are not permanent - they're learned neural pathways that can be changed
- New experiences literally rewire your brain - healing creates physical changes
- Your nervous system can learn new responses - you're not stuck with old reactions
- Integration practices strengthen new pathways - repetition makes healing stick

How Trauma Creates Neural Highways

When you experience trauma or chronic stress:

- Protective neural pathways get reinforced through repetition
- Fight/flight/freeze responses become automatic superhighways in your brain
- Parts develop as neural networks designed to keep you safe
- Your window of tolerance narrows as your brain prioritizes survival over connection

Think of it like this: If you always take the same route to work, that path becomes well-worn and automatic. Similarly, your brain creates "trauma superhighways" - fast, automatic routes to protection that bypass conscious choice.

The Neuroplastic Window: Where Change Becomes Possible

Neuroplasticity means these pathways can change, but it requires the right conditions:

- Safety to let protective parts relax their vigilance
- Presence to experience something new without being overwhelmed
- Repetition to strengthen new, healthier pathways
- Integration to make new patterns permanent

Neuroplasticity & Immersive Healing: How Your Brain Rewires Through Full-Sensory Experience

Your Brain Changes Through Rich, Multisensory Experiences

One of the most powerful aspects of neuroplasticity - your brain's ability to rewire itself - is that the richer and more immersive an experience, the stronger the neural changes it creates. This is why ketamine experiences can be so transformative: they engage all your senses simultaneously, creating profound opportunities for healing and growth.

How Multisensory Experiences Rewire Your Brain

The Science of Immersive Learning

Your brain doesn't process experiences through just one pathway. Instead, it creates complex neural networks that connect:

- Visual processing (what you see)
- Auditory processing (what you hear)
- Somatosensory processing (what you feel in your body)
- Olfactory processing (what you smell)
- Gustatory processing (what you taste)
- Emotional processing (how you feel)
- Memory consolidation (how experiences become part of you)

When multiple senses are engaged simultaneously, your brain creates stronger, more durable neural pathways. This is why immersive experiences during ketamine sessions can create lasting changes that purely cognitive approaches sometimes cannot reach.

Why Ketamine Creates Such Rich, Multisensory Healing

Breaking Down the Barriers Between Senses

Ketamine temporarily softens the boundaries between different sensory systems, allowing for experiences like:

- Synesthesia: Seeing sounds, hearing colors, feeling music
- Cross-modal perception: Where one sense triggers responses in another
- Enhanced sensory integration: All senses working together in new ways
- Embodied metaphors: Abstract concepts becoming physical sensations

The Immersion Effect: Why Full-Sensory Healing Works

Creating Rich Neural Networks

When you experience healing through multiple senses simultaneously:

- Your brain creates more neural connections - The more pathways involved, the stronger the memory and learning become
- Integration happens across brain regions - Different parts of your brain start communicating in new ways
- Emotional and somatic memories get processed - Not just cognitive understanding, but felt-sense transformation
- New patterns become embodied - Changes happen at a cellular and nervous system level

The Power of "As If" Experiences

During ketamine sessions, your brain often experiences healing "as if" it's really happening in your body:

- Your nervous system doesn't distinguish between vividly imagined and actually experienced events
- Healing visualizations create real physiological changes in stress hormones, heart rate, and brain chemistry
- Feeling safe in the ketamine space teaches your nervous system what safety actually feels like
- Experiencing love, connection, or peace creates neural templates for these states in daily life

The Neuroscience Behind Why This Works

Strengthening Positive Neural Networks

When you repeatedly engage multiple senses in healing experiences:

- **Default Mode Network Changes:** Your brain's "default" patterns shift from trauma-based to healing-based neural highways
- **Cross-Modal Integration:** Different brain regions learn to work together in healthier ways
- **Embodied Memory:** New experiences of safety, love, and connection become stored in your nervous system
- **Neuroplastic Reinforcement:** Each multisensory healing experience strengthens the neural pathways for resilience and wellbeing

From Trauma Patterns to Healing Patterns

Old Pattern: Trauma stored in fragmented sensory memories (visual flashbacks, body sensations, sounds, smells)

Ketamine Experience: Integrated, healing-focused multisensory experiences that feel safe and transformative

New Pattern: Rich, positive sensory associations that support regulation and growth

Integration: Daily practices that reinforce these new neural pathways through continued multisensory engagement

Integration Prompts: Bringing Session Experiences Into Daily Life

After Each Session:

Visual Integration:

- What did I see that I want to carry forward?
- How can I bring these healing colors/images into my daily environment?
- What visual reminders would support my continued healing?

Auditory Integration:

- What sounds or music from my session can I access during difficult moments?
- How can I use my voice (humming, singing, speaking) to regulate my nervous system?
- What healing words or phrases do I want to remember?

Somatic Integration:

- What body sensations felt most healing, and how can I recreate them?
- What movements want to continue in my daily life?
- How can I honor my body's wisdom in everyday moments?

Olfactory Integration:

- What scents would remind me of the peace I experienced?
- How can I use smell to anchor positive states in my daily life?

Gustatory Integration:

- How can I nourish myself in ways that honor my healing journey?
- What does my body want to taste, consume, or avoid right now?

The Beautiful Truth: Your Brain is Always Learning

Every moment of your life, your brain is changing based on your experiences. By consciously creating rich, multisensory healing experiences - both during ketamine sessions and in daily integration - you're rewiring your nervous system for greater resilience, connection, and joy.

Your healing is not just happening in your mind - it's happening in every cell, every sense, every neural pathway. You are actively participating in the transformation of your own brain and nervous system.

This is the power of immersive, multisensory healing: it changes not just how you think, but how you experience life itself.

How Ketamine Opens the Gateway to Understanding

Creating Optimal Conditions for Neuroplasticity

Ketamine creates the perfect storm of conditions for brain change:

1. Quieting the Default Mode Network

- Temporarily reduces activity in the brain networks responsible for rigid thought patterns
- Old trauma superhighways lose their grip on your experience
- Space opens for new neural connections to form
- Your brain becomes more flexible and receptive to change

2. Increasing BDNF (Brain-Derived Neurotrophic Factor)

- Ketamine triggers release of this "miracle grow for the brain" protein
- New neural connections form more easily for days after treatment
- Learning and memory consolidation enhance during the integration window
- Your brain is primed for positive change at the cellular level

3. Creating Psychological Safety for Change

- Protective parts temporarily step back, allowing access to deeper wisdom
- Exiled parts can be witnessed without overwhelming your system
- Self emerges with natural healing capacity to lead with curiosity and compassion
- New relationships between parts can form safely

The Neuroplastic Integration Window

The 24-72 hours after ketamine represent peak neuroplasticity when:

- New neural pathways are most moldable - like wet concrete that hasn't set
- Integration practices literally wire in changes through repetition and attention
- Your nervous system can learn new responses to old triggers
- Healthier patterns can become the new default with conscious practice

Expanding Your Window of Tolerance Through Neuroplasticity

During ketamine sessions:

- Protective hypervigilance pathways quiet, expanding your capacity upward
- Shutdown and dissociation patterns lift, expanding your capacity downward
- You can witness trauma without being retraumatized, creating new neural associations
- Integration becomes possible in ways that weren't neurologically accessible before

Accessing Body Wisdom Through Neural Rewiring

Ketamine helps you:

- Feel sensations that were too threatening to notice, creating new body-brain connections
- Hear the messages your nervous system has been trying to send
- Discharge trauma energy that's been stored somatically, completing interrupted responses
- Reconnect with your innate healing intelligence through new neural pathways

The Integration Connection: Where Philosophy Meets Neuroplasticity

Understanding these frameworks isn't just intellectual - it's practical guidance for rewiring your brain:

During Sessions

- Notice which nervous system state you're in
- Get curious about which parts are present
- Welcome whatever emerges with Self-compassion
- Trust your body's wisdom and timing
- Remember: your brain is actively rewiring in real-time

Between Sessions (The Critical Neuroplastic Window)

- Track your window of tolerance daily - this strengthens new neural pathways
- Build relationship with your different parts - repetition wires in Self-leadership
- Practice nervous system regulation tools - each use reinforces healthier responses
- Honor the pace of integration - forced change can reactivate protective patterns

The Science of Why Integration Works

Every time you:

- Journal about your experience - you're strengthening memory consolidation pathways
- Practice somatic awareness - you're building new body-brain connections
- Respond to triggers differently - you're weakening old trauma pathways
- Choose Self-compassion over self-criticism - you're rewiring your default internal voice

This isn't just emotional work - it's literally rebuilding your brain.

Your Healing is Already Happening: The Neuroplastic Truth

These frameworks help you understand that:

- Nothing about you is pathological - your responses are learned neural patterns that made sense
- Your symptoms are adaptive strategies wired in through experience, not character flaws
- Healing happens through new neural experiences - in relationship with your parts, your body, and safe others
- You have innate neuroplastic capacity - ketamine simply creates optimal conditions for your brain's natural ability to change
- Every moment of integration rewires your brain for resilience

The Interconnection: A Living System of Change

When you understand that:

- Your nervous system holds both trauma patterns and the capacity for new responses
- Your parts carry both protective strategies and gifts, all encoded in neural networks
- Ketamine creates optimal neuroplastic conditions for Self-led healing
- Integration literally rewires these patterns into healthier defaults
- Neuroplasticity means change is not just possible - it's inevitable with the right conditions

...you begin to see that you are not broken. You are a complex, wise system with an incredible capacity for change. Your brain has been doing its job perfectly - creating the most adaptive responses possible given your experiences.

Now, with ketamine opening the neuroplastic gateway and these frameworks as your map, you can consciously participate in rewiring your brain for thriving instead of just surviving.

Your healing journey honors the wisdom of your protective neural patterns while consciously creating new pathways that serve your authentic Self.

This is not just therapy - this is conscious evolution of your nervous system. This is coming home to the brain you were meant to have.

How to Use Your Integration Guide: A Guide to Finding Meaning in Every Aspect of Your Experience

The Purpose: Transforming Experience into Wisdom

This guide serves as your personal translator, helping you find meaning in the rich, multi-layered experiences that emerge during ketamine sessions. Your purpose is not to analyze or judge what happens, but to:

- Capture the full spectrum of your experience beyond just visuals
- Track patterns and themes that emerge across sessions
- Connect symbolic experiences to your healing journey
- Monitor your expanding capacity for regulation and self-compassion
- Build a relationship with your inner wisdom

Why Details Matters: Understanding the Language of Healing

Ketamine experiences speak in the language of symbol, sensation, and metaphor. Your unconscious mind uses every available channel - visual, somatic, emotional, relational - to communicate what needs healing.

Nothing that emerges is random or meaningless.

The Multidimensional Nature of Ketamine Experiences

Your brain processes healing information through multiple pathways simultaneously:

- Visual cortex creates imagery and symbols
- Somatosensory system generates physical sensations and movements
- Emotional processing centers release feelings and memories
- Relational networks explore connection and attachment patterns
- Pattern recognition systems reveal deeper structures and meanings

Each aspect carries important information about your healing process.

The Complete Spectrum: What to Track and Why

1. Visuals: The Mind's Symbolic Language

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Colors that appear (vibrant, muted, shifting) • Shapes and forms (geometric, organic, abstract) • Landscapes and environments (natural, architectural, surreal) • Beings or entities (human, animal, spiritual, archetypal) • Light and shadow patterns • Size and scale (microscopic to cosmic)	• Visuals often represent internal states and healing processes • Recurring imagery points to core themes needing attention • Colors can indicate emotional or energetic shifts • Landscapes may reflect your internal psychological terrain

2. Movements: Your Body's Wisdom in Action

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Spontaneous movements (flowing, jerky, rhythmic) • Urges to move that you may or may not follow • Changes in body posture or position • Sensations of flying, falling, expanding, contracting • Dance-like or ceremonial movements • Stillness that feels significant	• Movement often completes interrupted trauma responses • Your body knows what it needs to discharge and heal • Spontaneous movements can indicate nervous system regulation • Movement patterns may reveal how energy wants to flow in your life

3. Somatic Experiences: Your Body's Direct Communication

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Temperature changes (hot, cold, waves of warmth) • Pressure sensations (heavy, light, expanding, contracting) • Texture sensations (smooth, rough, flowing, stuck) • Pain or pleasure (where, intensity, quality) • Vibrations, buzzing, or energy movements • Heart rate, breathing changes • Muscle tension or release	• Trauma is stored somatically - your body holds the memories • Somatic experiences often indicate healing and integration happening • Your nervous system communicates through sensation • Body awareness builds your capacity for self-regulation

4. Emotions: The Full Spectrum of Feeling

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Primary emotions (joy, sadness, anger, fear, love) • Complex emotional states (grief mixed with relief, angry compassion) • Emotions that surprise you or feel unfamiliar • Waves, cycles, or sudden shifts in feeling • Places where emotions seem stuck or flowing • Absence of emotion where you might expect it	• Emotions carry important information about your needs and values • Suppressed emotions often emerge safely during ketamine sessions • Emotional release indicates nervous system discharge and healing • New emotional experiences expand your emotional range and resilience

5. Relationships: Your Connection Patterns Revealed

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Who appears in your experience (family, friends, strangers, guides, pets, characters from books or movies) • How you relate to these beings (connected, distant, fearful, loving) • Conversations or communications that occur • Feelings of being seen, understood, or misunderstood • Experiences of giving and receiving care • Relationship dynamics that mirror your life patterns	• Relationship patterns often reveal core attachment wounds and strengths • Healing relationships in the ketamine space can shift real-life dynamics • Your capacity for connection reflects nervous system regulation • Relational experiences show how your parts interact with others

6. Nature Elements: Connection to Life Force

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Water (oceans, rivers, rain, flowing) • Earth (mountains, caves, soil, grounding) • Fire (warmth, transformation, energy, purification) • Air (wind, breath, lightness, freedom) • Plants and trees (growth, rootedness, seasons) • Animals (instinct, power, guidance, companionship) • Weather patterns (storms, sunshine, change)	• Nature elements often represent healing forces and life energy • Connection to nature indicates nervous system regulation • Natural cycles mirror psychological healing processes • Animals may represent instinctual wisdom or protective energies

7. Textures: The Quality of Experience

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Surface qualities (smooth, rough, soft, hard) • Temperature textures (warm, cool, neutral) • Density (thick, thin, viscous, light) • Movement qualities (flowing, sticky, slippery, solid) • Fabrics or materials (silk, wood, metal, organic)	• Textures often indicate the quality of your internal experience • Rough textures might represent difficult emotions needing gentleness • Smooth, flowing textures often indicate healing and integration • Texture preferences can guide your integration practices

8. Colors: Emotional and Energetic Information

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Dominant colors and their intensity • Color combinations and transitions • How colors make you feel • Colors associated with different parts of your body • Colors that seem healing or difficult • Absence of color or monochrome experiences	• Colors carry emotional and energetic information • Color preferences may indicate what your system needs • Shifts in color perception can show nervous system changes • Colors often connect to chakras, emotions, and healing themes

9. Shapes and Patterns: The Architecture of Meaning

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Geometric patterns (circles, triangles, spirals, fractals) • Organic shapes (flowing, cellular, plant-like) • Repeating patterns or motifs • Symmetry or asymmetry • Size relationships and proportions • Patterns that morph or evolve	• Patterns often reveal deeper psychological structures • Sacred geometry may indicate spiritual or archetypal healing • Repeating patterns point to core themes needing integration • Shape evolution can show the progression of your healing process

10. Realizations: The "Aha" Moments

What to Notice	Why it Matters
• Sudden insights or understandings • Perspectives that feel completely new • Connections between different life experiences • Understanding about relationships or patterns • Clarity about decisions or directions • Knowledge that feels like remembering rather than learning	• Realizations often indicate parts integration and nervous system shifts • These insights carry the seeds of lasting change • New perspectives can shift entire life patterns • Realizations need integration practices to become embodied wisdom

Finding Patterns: The Key to Deeper Meaning

As you journal consistently, look for:

- Images or symbols that repeat across sessions
- Emotions that consistently emerge in certain contexts
- Somatic sensations that have similar qualities
- Relationship patterns that mirror your life
- Nature elements that repeatedly appear

Questions for Pattern Recognition

- What keeps showing up in my experiences?
- How do these patterns relate to my healing goals?
- What parts of me are represented by recurring symbols?
- How are these themes connected to my trauma or growth edges?
- What is my system trying to tell me through repetition?

What If I Experience Darkness or "Nothing" During Treatment?

You Are Not Alone - This is Very Common

Many patients experience darkness, void, or minimal visuals during their ketamine sessions - especially in the beginning of treatment. This is not unusual, not a sign that the medicine isn't working, and not something to fix or change. You are part of a large community of people whose systems initially choose protection through stillness and darkness.

Your System May Be Choosing Darkness for Healing

If your ketamine experience is filled with darkness, void, or feels like "nothing is happening," please know: ***This is not a failed session. This is your protective system creating exactly the conditions it deems safest for healing.***

Sometimes your wisest protectors determine that:

- Visual imagery might be too overwhelming right now
- Darkness provides the safety your system needs to begin healing
- Stillness and void are exactly what your nervous system is craving
- Protection through "nothingness" is the most loving response available

Your protective parts are essentially saying: "We need to test this medicine first. We need to make sure it's safe before we open the deeper vaults of experience."

Trust is Built Over Time - Shifts Often Happen

What many patients discover is that darkness often shifts as your system begins to trust the ketamine process.

The Beautiful Intelligence of Your Protective System

Your system's initial choice of darkness demonstrates incredible wisdom:

- It's protecting you from potential overwhelm
- It's building trust gradually, which creates lasting safety
- It's teaching you to find connection and meaning without external stimulation
- It's showing you that healing doesn't require dramatic experiences

There is No Wrong Way to Heal

Your experience is never wrong, never insufficient, never a failure. Your system is incredibly intelligent and will only allow what feels safe in each moment. Darkness can be:

- A protective cocoon where deep healing happens invisibly
- A rest space for an overstimulated nervous system
- Sacred emptiness where new possibilities can emerge
- Your system's way of saying "slow down, be still, just breathe"
- The perfect starting point for building trust with this healing process

Questions for Exploring Darkness with Curiosity

Safety and Presence:

- Do I feel safe in this darkness?
- What is the quality of this darkness - is it scary, peaceful, neutral, protective?
- Can I breathe easily here?
- Does this darkness feel familiar or new?

What You Need in This Space:

- What do I need right now in this darkness?
- What would help me feel more comfortable here?
- Is there anything I want to bring into this space with me?
- How can I be kind to myself at this moment?

Connection and Self-Compassion:

- Can I give myself reassurance right now?
- What would I tell a dear friend experiencing this same darkness?
- How can I connect with myself even without visuals?
- What parts of me might be choosing this protective darkness?

Finding Connection in the Void

Connect with Your Breath:

- Notice your breathing as an anchor to presence
- Let your breath remind you that you are alive and here
- Breathe compassion into the darkness

Connect with Your Body:

- Feel your body's weight and presence
- Notice any sensations, even subtle ones
- Send gentle appreciation to your body for keeping you safe

Connect with Self-Compassion:

- Place a hand on your heart if it feels good
- Speak kindly to yourself: "I am exactly where I need to be"
- Remember: Your system is protecting you with perfect wisdom

Connect with Your Intention:

- Remember why you're here - to heal, to grow, to care for yourself
- Your intention is working even in the darkness
- Healing happens in stillness too

The Healing Power of Darkness and Void

Darkness in ketamine sessions can represent:

- Deep rest for a hypervigilant nervous system
- Sacred emptiness from which new life emerges
- The womb space where transformation gestates
- Trust in the unknown as a healing practice
- Permission to just BE without having to see or understand everything

Integration Questions for Dark Sessions

During the session:

- How does this darkness feel in my body?
- What is this darkness protecting me from?
- Can I appreciate my system's wisdom in choosing this experience?
- How can I show love to the parts that need this protection?
- Am I noticing any subtle shifts, even in the darkness?

After the session:

- What did I learn about safety and protection?
- How did my body feel in the darkness?
- What parts of me felt cared for by this experience?
- What kind of darkness exists in my daily life that might need attention?
- Do I notice any changes in how I feel about the darkness over time?

Journal Prompt: "How has my relationship with darkness and protection evolved through my ketamine journey?"

Remember: Some Systems Prefer the Dark - And That's Perfectly Fine

Not everyone's system will shift toward vivid visuals, and this doesn't mean your healing is less profound. Some people's deepest healing continues to happen in:

- Quiet darkness with subtle body sensations
- Peaceful void with emotional processing
- Gentle darkness with profound realizations
- Protective stillness with somatic release

Your system knows exactly what it needs. Trust the wisdom of your unique healing path, whether it leads through darkness, light, or something beautifully in between.

Remember: You Are the Expert of Your Experience

This journal is your personal decoder ring for the language of your healing. Trust your interpretations, honor your pace, and remember that every detail that emerges - including darkness, stillness, or seeming "nothingness" - is your system's wisdom expressing itself.

Your ketamine experiences are not random - they are your unconscious mind's sophisticated healing communication system. This journal helps you become fluent in your own inner language, whether that language speaks in vivid imagery or protective darkness. There is no hierarchy of experiences - only your system's wisdom choosing what you need at each moment.

Setting Intentions for Your Treatments

The Difference Between Goals and Intentions

Goals vs. Intentions: Understanding the Difference

Goals are specific outcomes you want to achieve:

- "I want to stop feeling depressed"
- "I want to get over my trauma"
- "I want to never have anxiety again"
- "I want to have amazing visuals"

Intentions are qualities of being and approaching:

- "I want to be open to whatever emerges"
- "I want to meet my pain with compassion"
- "I want to listen to what my body needs"
- "I want to trust my healing process"

Why Intentions Work Better Than Goals in Ketamine Therapy

Goals can create pressure that actually works against healing:

- Your protective parts might feel they have to "perform"
- You might judge your experience as "successful" or "failed"
- You might force outcomes rather than allowing natural unfolding
- You might miss important healing that doesn't match your expectations

Intentions create space for authentic healing:

- They invite curiosity rather than demand results
- They honor your system's timing and wisdom
- They allow for surprise and unexpected gifts
- They reduce performance pressure on your parts

The Art of Setting Healing Intentions

When setting intentions, try to connect with your Self - the part of you that is naturally:

- Curious
- Compassionate
- Trusting
- Open

Categories of Healing Intentions

1. Intentions for Presence and Openness

- "I want to be present with whatever arises"
- "I want to approach my experience with curiosity"
- "I want to trust the wisdom of my system"
- "I want to be open to surprise and mystery"
- "I want to let go of needing to understand everything"

2. Intentions for Self-Compassion

- "I want to meet any pain with gentleness"
- "I want to offer myself the love I would give a dear friend"
- "I want to practice patience with my healing process"
- "I want to forgive myself for any judgments that arise"
- "I want to honor all parts of myself with kindness"

3. Intentions for Parts Work

- "I want to listen to what my parts need to tell me"
- "I want to appreciate how hard my protective parts have worked"
- "I want to offer comfort to any hurt parts that emerge"
- "I want to create space for all parts to be seen and heard"
- "I want to let Self lead with love and wisdom"

4. Intentions for Body and Nervous System

- "I want to listen to my body's wisdom"
- "I want to allow my nervous system to find its natural rhythm"
- "I want to complete any movements or expressions that want to happen"
- "I want to trust the sensations and feelings that arise"
- "I want to honor my body's needs for safety and comfort"

5. Intentions for Connection and Relationship

- "I want to explore how I relate to myself and others"
- "I want to experience healthy connection and boundaries"
- "I want to heal patterns that no longer serve me"
- "I want to feel worthy of love and belonging"
- "I want to trust in my capacity for healthy relationships"

6. Intentions for Release and Integration

- "I want to let go of what I'm ready to release"
- "I want to integrate what I learn into my daily life"
- "I want to honor both my strength and my vulnerability"
- "I want to embrace the full spectrum of my humanity"
- "I want to carry forward what serves my highest good"

How to Connect with Your Intentions

The Intention-Setting Process

1. Ground Yourself First

- Take several deep breaths
- Feel your feet on the floor
- Place a hand on your heart
- Notice your body in this moment

2. Connect with Your "Why"

- Why did you choose ketamine therapy?
- What drew you to this healing path?
- What do you hope will shift in your life?
- What would healing mean for you?

3. Listen to Your Parts

Ask your protective parts:

- "What do you need to feel safe in this process?"
- "What are your concerns about this treatment?"
- "How can I honor your protection while still healing?"

Ask your exiled parts:

- "What do you hope might be healed?"
- "What do you need to feel safe to emerge?"
- "What would you like me to know?"

4. Let Self Synthesize

From your Self, ask:

- "What feels most important for my healing right now?"
- "What quality of being do I want to bring to this session?"
- "How do I want to approach whatever arises?"

Sample Intention Templates

For Anxiety and Overwhelm

- "I want to trust that I can handle whatever emerges"
- "I want to find the calm, steady place within me"
- "I want to practice breathing with whatever arises"
- "I want to appreciate my nervous system's protection while also inviting ease"

For Depression and Numbness

- "I want to gently reconnect with my aliveness"
- "I want to welcome whatever feelings want to move"
- "I want to find the spark of hope within me"
- "I want to honor both my pain and my resilience"

For Trauma and PTSD

- "I want to move through this healing at my system's pace"
- "I want to complete anything that needs completing"
- "I want to reclaim parts of myself that got lost"
- "I want to transform survival responses into thriving responses"

For Addiction and Compulsions

- "I want to understand what my addictive patterns are protecting"
- "I want to find healthier ways to meet my needs"
- "I want to reconnect with my authentic desires and values"
- "I want to heal the pain that drives my compulsions"

For Relationships and Connection

- "I want to heal my capacity for healthy intimacy"
- "I want to understand my patterns in relationships"
- "I want to practice both giving and receiving love"
- "I want to strengthen my relationship with myself"

Remember: Your intentions are invitations to your healing, not demands. Hold them lightly, trust deeply, and let your system surprise you with its wisdom

Working with Your Intentions During Treatment

Before the Session

- Read your intentions quietly to yourself
- Share them with your treatment team if that feels right
- Ask your parts if they have anything to add
- Hold your intentions lightly, not as requirements

During the Session

- If you remember your intentions, let them guide you gently
- If you forget them completely, that's perfect too
- Trust that your system is working with your deepest intentions even when you're not conscious of them
- Allow the experience to unfold as it needs to

After the Session

- Reflect on how your intentions were met, perhaps in unexpected ways
- Notice what emerged that you hadn't specifically intended
- Appreciate how your system interpreted and worked with your intentions
- Adjust future intentions based on what you learned

When Intentions Feel Too Much

Sometimes even setting intentions can feel like pressure.

Try these gentler approaches:

- "I want to trust whatever wants to happen"
- "I want to be kind to myself no matter what occurs"
- "I want to remember that there's no wrong way to do this"

The Most Important Intention of All

If you could only hold one intention throughout your entire ketamine journey, let it be this: *"I want to approach my healing with the same love and patience I would offer my dearest friend."*

This intention encompasses:

- Self-compassion for whatever arises
- Trust in your system's wisdom
- Patience with the healing process
- Openness to unexpected gifts
- Kindness toward all parts of yourself

Post Session Notes-When you feel ready enough try to record as much as you can in each category. A sitter/family/friend/therapist may also scribe what you say.

Date: Session #:	Mindset:
Intention:	Movements:
Visuals:	
Textures:	Feelings/Emotions:
Relationships:	Realizations:
Somatics:	Other:

Post-Infusion Integration Journal Prompts

These gentle prompts are designed to help you honor your courage, process your healing, and appreciate the incredible work you're doing. After completing your immediate sensory log, use these questions to explore the deeper gifts of your session.

Approach these prompts with:

- Celebration of your bravery in choosing this healing path
- Compassion for all parts of your experience
- Wonder at your system's incredible wisdom
- Appreciation for how far you've already come
- Trust that you're exactly where you need to be

Remember: Every session is healing, even when it doesn't feel dramatic. Your willingness to show up for yourself is profound.

- What do you want to acknowledge about yourself for showing up to this healing work today?
- What felt most healing about today's experience, no matter how subtle?
- What would you want to say to any parts of yourself that felt scared, sad, or overwhelmed today?
- What new understanding about yourself emerged through today's experience?
- How did today's session add to the story of your healing journey?
- What does today's experience show you about your capacity to heal and grow?
- What old pattern or belief about yourself felt softer or less true after today's session?
- How did today's experience help you see yourself with more compassion?
- What aspect of today's experience feels like a gift to your future self?
- What changes in yourself do you want to celebrate from your recent sessions?
- How has your capacity for self-love and self-care grown through this process?
- What patterns of healing are you noticing across your sessions?
- How are you showing up differently in your relationships because of this work?
- What aspects of your healing journey fill you with the most pride?
- How has your understanding of your own strength and resilience deepened?
- What old stories about yourself are you beginning to release with love?
- What does your healing process teach you about your capacity for transformation?
- How has your relationship with your body, emotions, or inner world become more loving?

Glimmers Practice: Training Your Brain to Notice Safety and Joy

Understanding Glimmers: Your Nervous System's Natural Reset Button

What Are Glimmers?

While we often focus on **triggers** (moments when our nervous system detects danger and activates protection), **glimmers** are the opposite - micro-moments when our nervous system recognizes safety, connection, or joy.

Glimmers are:

- Tiny moments of nervous system regulation
- Brief experiences of safety, peace, or connection
- Small sparks of joy, wonder, or aliveness
- Micro-doses of healing that happen throughout your day
- Natural nervous system "resets" that return you to your window of tolerance

Examples of everyday glimmers:

- The way morning sunlight hits your coffee cup
- A brief moment of friendly eye contact with a stranger
- The sound of birds singing outside your window
- The feeling of your pet's soft fur under your hand
- A text message from someone who cares about you
- The taste of something delicious
- A song that makes you spontaneously smile
- The sensation of warm water in a shower
- A moment of feeling genuinely grateful
- Noticing your breath flowing easily and naturally

Why Glimmers Are Neuroplastically Powerful

Glimmers literally rewire your brain by:

- Creating positive neural pathways that compete with trauma patterns
- Training your nervous system to notice safety instead of only scanning for danger
- Building resilience through accumulated micro-experiences of regulation
- Expanding your window of tolerance gradually and sustainably
- Teaching your brain that the world contains beauty, safety, and connection

The more you notice glimmers, the more your brain creates neural highways for:

- Safety and regulation
- Joy and wonder
- Connection and love
- Peace and presence
- Gratitude and appreciation

The Daily Glimmers Practice: Rewiring Your Brain for Joy

Morning Glimmers Hunt (5 minutes)

As you start your day, actively look for 3 glimmers:

1. Sensory Glimmer

What do you notice with your senses that feels pleasant?

- The temperature of the air on your skin
- A color that catches your eye
- A sound that feels soothing
- A texture that feels comforting
- A scent that you enjoy

2. Connection Glimmer

What reminds you that you're not alone?

- A photo of someone you love
- Your pet greeting you
- A plant that you're caring for
- A memory of kindness
- The awareness that others are starting their day too

3. Body Glimmer

What feels good or peaceful in your body right now?

- Your heart beating steadily
- The feeling of being rested (even if partially)
- Your feet on the ground
- The expansion of your lungs as you breathe
- Any area that feels relaxed or at ease

Throughout the Day: Glimmer Collecting

Set gentle reminders (phone alerts, sticky notes, or natural transitions) to pause and notice:

"What's one glimmer available to me right now?"

Micro-glimmer examples:

- The way someone smiled at you
- A moment when your breathing felt easy
- A bite of food that tasted particularly good
- Sunlight or moonlight you noticed
- A color combination that pleased your eyes
- A sound that felt peaceful to your ears
- A moment of feeling capable or strong
- A brief sense of gratitude arising naturally
- Your body feeling supported by your chair
- A memory that brought warmth to your chest

Evening Glimmers Integration (5-10 minutes)

Before bed, reflect on your glimmers from the day:

1. Write Down 3-5 Glimmers

Record the glimmers you noticed (or discover them in reflection)

2. Choose One Glimmer to "Savor"

- Close your eyes and recall it fully
- Engage all your senses in the memory
- Feel how it affected your nervous system
- Let the positive feeling expand in your body
- Breathe with the sense of goodness for 30 seconds

3. Appreciate Your Brain's Growing Capacity

- "Today my nervous system noticed..."
- "I'm grateful my brain is learning to see..."
- "My system is getting better at finding..."

Daily Glimmers Tracking Templates

Simple Daily Glimmers Log

Date: _____

Morning Glimmers:

1. Sensory: _____

2. Connection: _____

3. Body: _____

Daytime Glimmers:

• _____ (Time: ____)

• _____ (Time: ____)

• _____ (Time: ____)

Evening Reflection: The glimmer I want to savor: _____.

How noticing glimmers affected my day:

_____.

Tomorrow I want to pay attention to: _____.

Weekly Glimmers Pattern Review

Week of: _____

Most common types of glimmers I noticed:

- | | | |
|---|---|--|
| ☐ Visual (colors, light, beauty) | ☐ Auditory (sounds, music, voices) | ☐ Body sensations |
| ☐ Taste/smell | ☐ Gratitude moments | ☐ Movement |
| ☐ Nature | ☐ Achievements | ☐ Gratitude moments |
| ☐ Connection (people, pets, community) | | |
| ☐ Touch (textures, temperature) | | |
| ☐ Other: _____ | | |

Patterns I'm noticing:

Times of day I notice most glimmers: _____

Places where I find glimmers easily: _____

Types of glimmers that affect my nervous system most: _____.

This week, my glimmer practice helped me:

- | | | |
|--|--|---|
| ☐ Feel more regulated | ☐ Notice beauty more easily | ☐ Connect with others |
| ☐ Feel more grateful | ☐ Sleep better | ☐ Handle stress better |
| ☐ Feel more hopeful | ☐ Stay present | ☐ Other: _____ |

Glimmers in Challenging Moments

The "Emergency Glimmer" Practice

When you're triggered or activated, glimmers can help regulate your nervous system:

1. Pause and take one conscious breath
2. Look around for something small that doesn't feel threatening
3. Notice one tiny thing you can appreciate right now
4. Feel how this small glimmer affects your nervous system
5. Breathe with this micro-moment of safety or beauty

Emergency glimmer examples:

- The color of an object near you
- The feeling of air moving in and out of your lungs
- A sound that isn't harsh (even if it's just silence)
- The fact that you're trying to care for yourself right now
- Your feet making contact with the ground
- The softness of your clothes against your skin

Glimmers During Difficult Days

On hard days, look for the smallest possible glimmers:

- The fact that you got out of bed
- One sip of water that felt good
- A moment when pain lessened, even slightly
- Someone who said hello to you
- A pet or plant that's alive because you care for it
- The fact that you're still trying, still breathing

Advanced Glimmers Practices

Creating Glimmer Anchors

Once you're comfortable noticing glimmers, create ways to recall and recreate these positive nervous system states:

Sensory Glimmer Anchors

- Visual: Keep photos of glimmer moments on your phone
- Auditory: Create playlists of sounds that generate glimmers
- Tactile: Keep textures nearby that feel soothing
- Olfactory: Use scents that you associate with glimmer moments
- Gustatory: Keep flavors available that generate positive feelings

Somatic Glimmer Anchors

- Breathing patterns that accompanied glimmer moments
- Body positions that felt most regulated
- Movements that generated positive feelings
- Touch practices that feel nurturing

Environmental Glimmer Creation

- Design spaces that naturally generate glimmers
- Plan activities that tend to create positive moments
- Spend time in places where glimmers come easily
- Connect with people who naturally create glimmers

Glimmer Sharing Practice

Share glimmers with others to amplify their neuroplastic effect:

- Tell someone about a glimmer you noticed
- Ask others about their glimmers
- Create glimmer rituals with family or friends
- Write about glimmers in thank you notes or messages

The Neuroscience: Why This Works

How Glimmers Rewire Your Brain

Repeated glimmer practice creates:

- Positive neural pathways that compete with trauma pathways
- Nervous system flexibility - ability to shift between states more easily
- Resilience building through accumulated positive micro-experiences
- Attention training - your brain learns what to notice and focus on
- Regulation skills - faster return to your window of tolerance
- Joy cultivation - your capacity for positive emotions expands naturally

Long-term Brain Changes

Over time, your brain becomes:

- More skilled at noticing safety and beauty in your environment
- Faster at self-regulation through positive focus
- More resilient to stress and triggers
- Naturally oriented toward connection and joy
- Capable of finding internal resources even in difficult moments

Remember: Every Glimmer Counts

Your glimmers practice helps your brain remember:

- The world contains beauty and safety alongside difficulty
- You have the capacity to notice and receive goodness
- Small moments of joy and peace are always available
- Your nervous system can learn to relax and regulate naturally
- Healing happens in tiny, daily moments as much as in dramatic experiences

Every glimmer you notice is rewiring your brain for greater joy, safety, and connection. You're not just observing positive moments - you're actively sculpting your nervous system toward wellbeing. This practice works alongside your ketamine therapy, building positive neural networks between sessions and creating a foundation of safety and joy that supports your entire healing journey.